

“ Upon the ... performance of the duties of **Quartermaster**, an army depends for its **ability to move**. ”

MONTGOMERY MEIGS, ANNUAL REPORT TO THE SECRETARY OF WAR, 1862

Supplying the South

While the Confederacy did not face the challenges associated with supplying armies of invasion across vast distances, it began the conflict with little of the industrial capacity needed for waging war. When Josiah Gorgas—another prewar U.S. Army officer and a veteran of the War with Mexico—was made head of the crucial Ordnance Bureau, he could count only on the Tredegar Iron Works in Richmond, Virginia, to produce heavy ordnance. There were two small arsenals at Richmond and Fayetteville, North Carolina, for the production of small arms.

With astonishing ingenuity, Gorgas found ways around these difficulties, including blockade running, domestic scavenging, and simple improvisation. During the war's first year, while the Union blockade on the South remained relatively porous, he purchased much of the new nation's needs in Europe. At home, in his search for the raw materials for ordnance production, Gorgas tapped resources as diverse as limestone caves in the Appalachians, chamberpots, stills, church bells, and weapons discarded on the battlefield. The men responsible for feeding and clothing the Southern armies had far less success. Quartermaster General Abraham Myers—eventually relieved in August 1863—and Commissary General Lucius B. Northrop never really found ways to surmount the Confederacy's basic disadvantages, which included its limited rail network.